

Capital City Trail & Military Ridge State Trail

Dane County Planning & Development -- Updated October 2025

CAPITAL CITY TRAIL

Total length:	17 miles (Madison city limits; off-street paved)
Surface:	Asphalt, 10 ft wide
Seasonal closure:	None -- plowed Nov-Mar (check city updates for ice closures)
Trailhead (west):	Near Fish Hatchery Road / Dunn's Marsh (free parking)
Trailhead (east):	Monona Terrace / Lake Monona lakeshore
Closest to Dudgeon-Monroe:	Monroe St access via SW section near Midvale Blvd
Elevation gain:	Moderate; rolling 350-450 ft across full length
Notable features:	Lake Monona waterfront, Olin Park, Wingra Park, Brittingham Park

Common Jacob Graves routes:

- Dudgeon-Monroe -> Monroe St -> Fish Hatchery Rd -> Cap City Trail east -> Olin Park turnaround: ~22 mi / 410 ft gain
- Full length (west -> east -> return via Beltline path): ~34 mi / 580 ft gain (weekend long ride)
- Quick loop via Wingra Park: ~14 mi, good pre-work ride on distillery off-days

MILITARY RIDGE STATE TRAIL

Total length:	40 miles (Fitchburg to Dodgeville; paved limestone screenings)
Surface:	Limestone screening (firm when dry; soft/muddy after rain)
Seasonal closure:	Open year-round; no winter maintenance beyond Verona segment
Eastern trailhead:	Fitchburg Community Center (1611 S Syene Rd) -- parking available
Key milepoints:	Fitchburg 0 mi / Verona 6 mi / Riley 11 mi / Barneveld 22 mi / Dodgeville 40 mi
Elevation gain:	Significant; 760-920 ft for Fitchburg-to-Riley roundtrip (Jacob's standard)
Best months:	April-October; avoid after rain first 24 hrs (surface soft)
Trail notes:	Shared with walkers; 15 mph speed limit on crowded segments; yield to horses near Verona

Common Jacob Graves routes:

- Fitchburg trailhead -> Verona -> Riley -> return: ~22 mi / 760 ft gain (standard Tuesday/Thursday route)
- Fitchburg -> Barneveld -> return: ~44 mi / 1,060 ft gain (Horribly Hilly prep ride, pre-June)
- Fitchburg -> Verona out-and-back: ~12 mi warm-up, good for short pre-teaching windows

SEASONAL NOTES & SAFETY

- Spring (Mar-Apr): Cap City cleared first; Military Ridge soft until late April. Watch for frost heave on Cap City asphalt sections near Olin Park.
- Summer (May-Sep): Both trails at peak. Military Ridge crowded Saturdays 8-11 AM. Start early.
- Fall (Oct-Nov): Leaf cover on Cap City can obscure pavement cracks. Military Ridge turns golden -- best scenery of the year.
- Winter (Dec-Feb): Cap City plowed by city but watch for ice. Military Ridge not maintained. Indoor trainer recommended Nov-Mar per knee protocol (Dr. Fitzgerald, Nov 2024 note).

Source: Dane County Parks (danecountyparks.com/trails), City of Madison Traffic Engineering, Wisconsin DNR Military Ridge State Trail map (pub. 2023). Personal route notes compiled October 2025.